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From the editor-in-chief

A country like India should have a much larger presence on the world stage than we do at the moment. We are, after all, a nuclear power, have a strong, functioning democracy and an economy that is the fourth-largest in the world and one of the success stories of this decade.

Yet in the corridors of global power, India is seen as a timid and indecisive state. An easy target for terrorists, given to flip-flops over policy, unable to take a tough stand on any issue. The last 10 days have certainly brought that India to the forefront again. They have left the world with the distinct impression that India's foreign policy is adrift and directionless.

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has not been able to satisfactorily explain why we have softened our stance over dialogue with Pakistan after the talks in Sharm el-Sheikh. Relations with Pakistan are always complex and, in the aftermath of 26/11, particularly sensitive. There is no reason for us to divorce terrorism from the composite dialogue with Pakistan, but oddly in Sharm el-Sheikh we agreed to do just that.

Yielding ground seems to have become the leitmotif of India's foreign policy. The benchmarks of a robust foreign policy are internal security and territorial integrity. India scores poorly on both counts. Despite pacts and lines of control, we put up with regular intrusions from Pakistan and China. South Block has no cogent plan for the North-east and 10 years after Kargil, there is still no infrastructure on our eastern and western frontiers to efficiently guard what belongs to us.

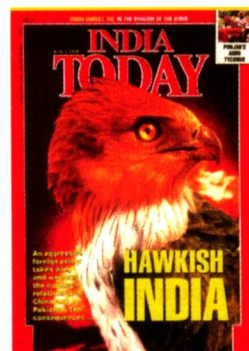
There appears to be no consensus or continuity in India's foreign policy objectives. The Indo-US nuclear deal was a ground-breaking development during the first term of the Manmohan Singh Government but India did not adequately capitalise on its hard-won proximity to the United States. Instead, we seemed to have become almost a poodle of the Americans: succumbing to pressure on going soft on Pakistan, climate change, non-proliferation and the WTO.

India's profile in the world may have grown but its influence overseas seems to have waned, especially in comparison to its larger and more purposeful neighbour China. Our traditional involvement in the Middle East is now next to negligible. Other than Pakistan, our relations with three other neighbours are testy. We have failed to capitalise on our Non-Aligned Movement alliances in Africa to our economic advantage. China has stepped into the breach and India seems to be content merely with the leftovers.

Our cover story this week takes a sharp look at the drift in India's foreign policy and how it can be checked and given direction. Managing Editor Raj Chengappa put together the package which contains an essay by Editor-at-Large S. Prasannarajan and additional reporting from Senior Editor Saurabh Shukla.

If India wants to be taken seriously in world diplomacy, it must build political consensus on fundamental issues like terror, have a world view in which certain goals are set and follow it up with consistent action. This translates into having peace on our borders, strategic autonomy to deal with major powers and a push to promote economic prosperity through trade. In Nehru's time, we were leaders of the Third World because of his soaring idealism. There is no reason today why a country of our stature should not have its voice heard at the high tables of world diplomacy.

(Aroon Purie)



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